

The Two Edges of Hatred

A study of hate, contempt, hostility, and their kin in the inner life of Scripture

Hatred is the one inner state the modern world is most confident is simply a sickness — something to be reduced, treated, and grown out of. Scripture is not so simple about it, and that complication is the first and deepest thing this study has to report. The very same word that names a condemned and murderous passion also names a duty: "O you who love the LORD, hate evil!" (Psa 97:10). The capacity to turn against something is, in the Bible, a capacity that can be rightly or wrongly used — wrong when it turns against a person made in God's image, right when it turns against the evil that destroys him. To study hatred honestly is to hold those two edges together.

This study follows hatred across six related forms, which together cover far more ground than the bare word suggests. At the centre is **hatred itself** — the felt turning-away from a person or thing. Around it stand its near kin: **contempt**, the cold verdict that another is worthless; **loathing**, the visceral, almost physical recoil from what is detestable; **reproach**, hostility put into words, and the disgrace it inflicts; **enmity**, the settled standing of being someone's adversary; and **cruelty**, not a passing feeling but the fixed character of a person who is unmoved by suffering. Read together they are not six versions of one feeling. They are the negative pole of the inner life expressed as a feeling, a verdict, a spoken wound, a recoil, a relationship, and a trait — and, taken as a whole, they are the exact reverse of everything love is.

The divine pattern: a hatred God shares — and a cruelty he does not

The most striking thing about this dark family is that part of it belongs to God, and part of it cannot. At one end, hatred and loathing of *evil* are attributed to God himself, plainly and often. "There are six things that the LORD hates, seven that are an abomination to him" (Pro 6:16); "the LORD abhors the bloodthirsty and deceitful man" (Psa 5:6); "I abhor the pride of Jacob" (Amo 6:8). God's hatred is never the resentment of a rival or the cruelty of a tyrant; it is the holy recoil of perfect goodness from what is evil. And precisely because God hates evil, the person being remade in his likeness is *commanded* to share that hatred: "The fear of the LORD is hatred of evil" (Pro 8:13); "Hate evil, and love good, and establish justice in the gate" (Amo 5:15). Here hatred is not a defect but an alignment — the inner being rightly set against what God is set against.

At the other end of the family stands a form that has no counterpart in God whatever. Cruelty is borne by no holy original; there is no verse in which God is cruel, and the evidence offers not a single instance. This is the sharpest line the study draws. The capacity to hate can be turned toward evil and become a likeness of God; the disposition to be cruel images nothing in him at all — it is wholly fallen, a corruption with no good root. Between these two poles lie contempt and reproach, and their relation to God runs mostly the other way: they are chiefly things done *against* him — "Why does the wicked renounce God?" (Psa

10:13) — and things he answers, lifting the disgrace his people bear: "Today I have rolled away the reproach of Egypt from you" (Jos 5:9). The family therefore maps onto God unevenly: it resembles him only where it hates evil, and least of all where it grows cruel.

What these six are

This family runs across the whole range of what an inner state can be. Hatred is an *act and a condition* — a thing done and a thing borne. Contempt is a *verdict* — the passing of judgement that another is beneath regard. Loathing is a *recoil* — aversion with a bodily, sometimes ritual, colouring, the response to what is "detestable" and unclean: "You shall utterly detest and abhor it" (Deu 7:26). Reproach is partly an *act* (the taunt thrown) and partly a *condition* (the disgrace that settles on the one taunted). Enmity is a *relationship* — the standing of an adversary, not an episode of feeling. And cruelty is a *character trait* — the settled ruthlessness of a person, "the mercy of the wicked is cruel" (Pro 12:10). One family, six different kinds of thing.

What unifies them is what they oppose. Each of the six is the exact negative of one of the goods of the inner life: hatred is the opposite of love, contempt the opposite of honour, loathing the opposite of delight, reproach the opposite of glory, enmity the opposite of friendship and peace, and cruelty the opposite of mercy. This family is not the reverse of a single virtue; it is a many-fronted assault on love, honour, delight, peace, and mercy all at once. And running through it is the same double-edged quality already seen in hatred — a capacity that bends both ways. The same recoil that is sin when aimed at a brother is righteousness when aimed at falsehood: "Through your precepts I get understanding; therefore I hate every false way" (Psa 119:104). The family's darkest member, by contrast, is named in the New Testament by what it lacks: the cruel are "heartless, unappeasable... brutal, not loving good" (2Ti 3:3) — hatred not of evil but of the good itself.

Where these live in the inner person

When these states are located in the inner person at all, they sit in the soul and the heart — the soul most of all for hatred, the heart for the cold verdict of contempt. One member alone reaches into the body: loathing, the recoil from the ritually detestable, is the only form seated in the flesh, which fits its nature as a near-physical revulsion. And the negative here is as telling as the positive. None of these states is ever located in the spirit, the mind, or the conscience. That last silence is worth pausing over: a family of hatreds, contempts, and cruelties that never once engages the conscience — never appears, in this evidence, as the inner witness of right and wrong. These are states that *act*; they are not states that examine the self.

But the most important fact about where this family lives is how much of it does not live "inside" at all. A large share of these terms name something outward — an act of taunting, the social fact of being an adversary, the borne condition of public disgrace. Reproach is mostly a thing suffered in the eyes of others; enmity is entirely a matter of where one stands toward another, not a feeling within. This is unusual among the inner states, and it means the family lives on the boundary between the inner person and the outer world. Hatred

begins as a turning of the soul, but it does not stay there — it hardens into a relationship, escapes into speech, and inflicts itself on others as a public wound.

Which inner capacities these engage

For all its force, this is a family that uses a remarkably narrow range of the inner powers. Only three are ever engaged: feeling, the appraising judgement that weighs another's worth, and the moral sense that condemns. Hatred at its core is feeling fused with judgement — it both *feels against* its object and *judges* it, which is why it is at once so hot and so sure of itself. Contempt is almost pure verdict, the cold reckoning that another is worthless. Reproach carries the *felt* sting of disgrace. Cruelty keeps only a remnant of feeling, the ferocity of the ruthless. But the wider powers of the inner life are simply absent. This family does not perceive, remember, imagine, or create; and most tellingly, in all of it the conscience is never engaged and the relational capacity — the very equipment for bonding with others — is never positively at work. That last point is almost a definition: these are the states in which the power made for communion is turned to its opposite use, and the conscience that might check them stays silent.

There is one quiet implication in this. Because the same state carries both an inner pole (the felt verdict, the inward recoil) and an outer pole (the taunt thrown, the cruel deed done), the line between what is felt and what is done runs *through* each of these states, not between them. Hatred is never merely private; it is always tending toward its own expression.

How hatred moves between God and people

This is an intensely relational family, and its dealings with God run in two sharply different directions. From God's side, the movement is His holy hatred of evil and His lifting of His people's disgrace. From the human side, the movement is hostility — and it is striking how much of humanity's hatred is aimed *upward*, at God himself. The contempt that renounces God, the taunt that defies him, the hatred that opposes him: these are among the family's most prominent expressions. The defiance of Goliath and the renouncing heart of the wicked are of a piece — the creature turning its hostility against its Maker.

Between people, every member of the family is at work, and two of them are best understood by who bears the cost. Reproach is most often a thing *received* — the disgrace that falls on a person from others, and a disgrace the faithful sometimes bear precisely for God's sake: "the reproaches of those who reproach you have fallen on me" (Psa 69:9). Cruelty, by contrast, is a thing *inflicted* — its whole meaning is the suffering it works on a victim. The family thus has a sufferer's side and an aggressor's side, and the same family that describes the hater also describes, with great feeling, the one who is hated. It is, more than most regions of the inner life, a study told from both ends of the wound.

How these are formed and suffered

Of how hatred grows, deepens, or is healed over the course of a life, this kind of study can say relatively little — the evidence here is thin, and honesty requires admitting it. Two

threads, though, carry real weight. The first is the way this family reaches toward the end of all things. Loathing and contempt are given a final, eschatological form: the resurrection raises "some to shame and everlasting contempt" (Dan 12:2), and the abhorrence of evil is shown stretching past death into judgement. The second thread is suffering, and here the family divides cleanly. Reproach *is* suffering — the borne disgrace of the afflicted, the cry of the psalms. Cruelty *causes* suffering — it is the active agent of affliction, the hand that wounds. One member of the family is something endured; another is the very thing that makes endurance necessary. That the same family holds both the wound and the one who inflicts it is part of its grim completeness.

How these relate to one another and to love

These six are not a flat list of parallel negatives; they are built out of one another. Contempt and loathing — the cold devaluing of another and the disgusted recoil from him — are the components out of which full hatred is composed; hatred is, in a sense, contempt and revulsion fused and set alight. Enmity is what that feeling becomes when it settles into a standing relationship: the same root that gives the word for "hate" gives the word for "enemy," so that the feeling and the relation are one thing seen at two moments. Cruelty is what hostility becomes when it hardens from a relationship into a character. And reproach is what contempt becomes when it is spoken aloud — the inner verdict made public as a taunt. The family is an organism, not a heap.

Set against the whole of it stands love, and the opposition is total and direct: "Hatred stirs up strife, but love covers all offenses" (Pro 10:12). Where hatred magnifies every wrong into a quarrel, love draws a covering over it; the two produce opposite worlds. Yet the relationship is not only opposition. The wider testimony of Scripture shows love as the very thing whose betrayal breeds the fiercest hatred, and it shows the experiences of the hated person — grief, anger, fear — gathering around the one who bears reproach. Hatred, in other words, cannot be understood on its own. It is defined by the love it refuses, the honour it withholds, the peace it breaks.

The view from outside Scripture

The modern study of these states has mapped them with real precision, and at point after point its findings line up with the biblical picture. Psychologists describe hatred as a compound of devaluation, disgust, and passion — almost exactly the corpus's portrait of a hatred composed of cold contempt and visceral loathing set alight by feeling. Researchers on close relationships have found contempt to be the single most corrosive attitude one person can hold toward another, which matches the gravity Scripture gives the cold verdict of worthlessness. The study of disgust traces its path from the body's recoil at contamination to the mind's recoil at moral evil — the very movement the language of loathing makes, from the ritually unclean to the morally detestable. The study of cruelty describes the "moral disengagement" by which a person switches off the inner restraints that would otherwise stop him, which fits a state defined precisely by the silence of the conscience. And the discovery that social rejection registers in the brain like physical pain

confirms what the language of reproach already implied — that disgrace is genuinely *felt*, a real wound and not a figure of speech.

At one point, though, the biblical account stands somewhere the sciences cannot follow. They treat this entire field as pathology — damage to be reduced, hostility to be lowered, disgust to be outgrown. Scripture agrees about most of it, but not all, and the exceptions are exactly the ones the human sciences have no category for: a *commanded* hatred of evil, a *holy* abhorrence borne by God himself, and the stark judgement that of all these states cruelty alone has no divine original. To hate evil can be a duty and a likeness of God; to be cruel is a corruption with no good in it anywhere. A purely clinical account, which can only measure how much hostility a person feels, has no way to tell the two apart — and telling them apart is the whole point.

The whole in one view

Hatred and its kin, across the breadth of Scripture, are the inner being turned *against*. The family runs from a felt rejection through a cold verdict, a bodily recoil, a spoken wound, a settled enmity, and a fixed cruelty — six different kinds of thing, united by what they oppose, which is everything love is. They live in the soul and the heart, reach into the body only as loathing and out into the world as taunt and deed, and they engage a strikingly narrow band of the inner powers, never once the conscience. Much of the family is aimed upward at God in defiance, and much of it is borne downward as the suffering of the reproached and the cruelly used.

Its deepest disclosure is the one the study began with: that this dark capacity is double-edged. The same power that makes a person able to hate his brother makes him able to hate the evil that would destroy them both — and the whole moral weight falls on which it is. Rightly turned, hatred is the inner being aligned with a God who himself abhors what is evil; wrongly turned, it is the image-bearer set against his own kind and against his Maker. Only at its furthest, cruellest edge does the family lose even the possibility of good, in the one disposition that resembles nothing in God. The reader is left not with a simple verdict against an ugly emotion, but with a sharper and more searching question — not *whether* a person hates, but *what*.